

A DECISION-BASED TEACHING RECONSTRUCTION

FIRE, SAFETY & SYSTEMS

Governance, evidence, authority, and uncertainty

A private decision game about what the evidence establishes,
what action it justifies, and when an organization should stop
looking.

HOW TO USE THIS ZINE

HOW TO READ THIS

Make each decision before continuing. After each decision, turn the page to learn what the surviving record establishes and what remains uncertain.

PROVENANCE VOCABULARY

DOCUMENTED
Supported by a contemporaneous, public, or otherwise identified source at the level claimed.
RECOLLECTED
Participant or contributor recollection not independently verified at the level claimed.
UNKNOWN
A gap the surviving reconstruction does not establish.
TEACHING SCENARIO
Generalized, normalized, or constructed material used to make the exercise understandable or playable.

INTENT

Your organization knows how to manage a planned emergency. What do you do when substantially the same hazard happens without being planned?

Fire itself was not anomalous at the event. The event intentionally supported art designed to burn and had a system for managing it. Before the event the incident year, official

LOOK BACK AT YOUR DECISIONS

Safety never needs the sculpture to become a solved whodunit in order to learn from it.

The operational questions are simpler and more durable:

- What happened outside the plan?
- Why was it possible?
- What controls were absent or bypassed?
- What does the organization need to know next time?
- Which questions belong to Safety, and which need to move somewhere else?

PLAY AGAIN

Return to one decision and change your answer. Ask which risk the alternative accepts instead.

PRIVACY, SOURCES & CONTRIBUTIONS

This teaching text is de-identified, not anonymous. Identifying details and organizational terminology may be generalized while preserving the decisions, constraints, evidence distinctions, and outcomes needed for the exercise.

SOURCES

Sources include public records, contemporaneous documents, and participant recollections as identified throughout. Zine-specific source entries follow when supplied.

WHAT THE RECORD SHOWS

DO YOU NEED TO SOLVE THE MYSTERY TO FIX THE SAFETY PROBLEM?

The organization eventually separated the general safety message from sculpture-specific attribution. The organizational record says a general unplanned-burn statement was completed and reviewed, although no corresponding official Announce publication has been located. The attribution and disciplinary process continued separately and ultimately ended without a definitive surviving factual finding identifying the igniter.

participant communications required advance registration and Fire Core approval for art intended to burn so that fire-safety planning could occur. The sculpture did not have a burn plan. When it burned on Burn Night, Safety was therefore responding not simply to fire, but to an unplanned version of a hazard the organization already knew how to manage when planned.

The second problem develops after the immediate incident: what does Safety do when organizational leadership may not agree with Safety about how the incident should be followed up or understood? The historical record establishes disagreement and concern; it does not establish that Organizational Leadership obstructed Safety or that Safety actually stifled community discussion.

WHO ARE YOU?

You are part of the event's Safety leadership, responding first to an unplanned fire and then to the organizational follow-up.

ROLES IN THIS STORY

Safety — investigates hazards, system vulnerabilities, and future prevention.

Fire — communicates and manages fire-safety expectations.

Organizational Leadership — handles governance, attribution, and discipline.

Participants / Witnesses — may provide direct observations or other information.

TIMELINE

1	Burn Night An art object burns without an approved burn plan.
2	After the Event Safety seeks information and reviews the incident.
3	Following Months Safety and organizational leadership separate operational learning from attribution and discipline.
4	Investigation Closure Attribution remains unresolved in the surviving record.

DECISION 5 DO YOU NEED TO SOLVE THE MYSTERY TO FIX THE SAFETY PROBLEM?

CONTEXT

The attribution investigation continues for months. Evidence remains incomplete and the identity of the person who physically ignited the sculpture is not definitively established in the surviving record.

WHAT DO YOU DO?	DECISION 5
Can Safety still close the operational loop?	
A Yes.	
B No.	
COMMIT BEFORE YOU CONTINUE.	Mark your choice, then turn the page.

WHAT THE RECORD SHOWS

WHAT IF SAFETY AND ORGANIZATIONAL LEADERSHIP DISAGREE?

August the incident year Board minutes record concern that Safety's information-gathering tone might have changed subsequent online discussion and may have short-circuited broader discussion hoped for by the artist. The minutes establish that Organizational Leadership held this concern. They do not establish that Safety actually suppressed or changed the conversation, and the underlying online discussion is presently unavailable for independent review.

DECISION 1 SOMETHING UNEXPECTED IS BURNING

CONTEXT

A large art object is burning at an event where intentional burns are normal.

WHAT DO YOU DO?	DECISION 1
A It is Burn Night; treat it like the other fires.	
B Treat it as an unplanned fire incident and determine what controls are missing.	
C First determine who the artist is and whether they wanted it burned.	
D Something else.	
COMMIT BEFORE YOU CONTINUE.	Mark your choice, then turn the page.

WHAT THE RECORD SHOWS

SOMETHING UNEXPECTED IS BURNING

The sculpture burned at approximately 11 p.m. on Burn Night. Ranger and Fire Safety leadership later stated that the artist did not have a burn plan and that the organization did not know who ignited it. They said the burn violated established fire-art rules and did not condone it.

DECISION 4
WHAT IF SAFETY AND ORGANIZATIONAL LEADERSHIP DISAGREE?

CONTEXT

Organizational leadership later expresses concern that the way Safety gathered information may have affected a broader community or artistic conversation. Safety still has a legitimate need to understand an unauthorized fire.

WHAT DO YOU DO?	DECISION 4
A Stop the investigation because the Organizational Leadership objects to its effects.	
B Continue exactly as before because Safety owns all questions involving the incident.	
C Clarify Safety's operational purpose, document what is known, and separate system-learning work from governance, discipline, and broader cultural discussion.	
D Escalate the disagreement as a governance question while preserving the operational record.	
E Something else.	
COMMIT BEFORE YOU CONTINUE.	Mark your choice, then turn the page.

WHAT THE RECORD SHOWS

WHAT EXACTLY ARE YOU INVESTIGATING?

By January the following year, the event explicitly separated functions. Fire was tasked with communicating the general lesson that unplanned burns were unacceptable, while Organizational Leadership stated that it—not Safety—would pursue the question of the person responsible. Safety could provide information from its investigation.

DECISION 2 THE FIRE IS OUT. IS THE INCIDENT OVER?

CONTEXT

The immediate fire has ended. There may have been no catastrophic outcome. You still do not know why the burn occurred or who ignited the object.

WHAT DO YOU DO?	DECISION 2
A Close the incident because the immediate hazard has passed.	
B Conduct an After Action Review focused on system vulnerabilities and future prevention.	
C Focus primarily on identifying and disciplining the person who ignited it.	
D Hand the entire matter to Organizational Leadership.	
E Something else.	
COMMIT BEFORE YOU CONTINUE.	Mark your choice, then turn the page.

WHAT THE RECORD SHOWS

THE FIRE IS OUT. IS THE INCIDENT OVER?

Safety framed its follow-up through the After Action Report process. Its public request said the purpose was to identify vulnerabilities in systems and improve future operations, and asked direct witnesses with relevant information to contact Fire or submit an AAR. Safety also stated that its goal was not to suppress experimental or risky art, but to support it through reasonable risk mitigation.

DECISION 3
WHAT EXACTLY ARE YOU INVESTIGATING?

CONTEXT

Witness information is incomplete. People want to know who did it. Safety also needs to understand how an unplanned burn became possible.

WHAT DO YOU DO?	DECISION 3
Which questions belong to the safety investigation? Questions may include: A ☐ Why was an unplanned burn possible? B ☐ Which safeguards or planning processes were bypassed? C ☐ What would reduce the chance or consequences of recurrence? D ☐ What did witnesses directly observe? E ☐ Who physically ignited the object? F ☐ Who should determine individual responsibility or discipline?	
COMMIT BEFORE YOU CONTINUE.	Mark your choice, then turn the page.